Amba Utpadak Sahakari Sanstha Maryadit, along with the Director of Research, Balasaheb Sawant Konkan Krishi Vidyapeeth, Konkan Hapus Amba Utpadak Ani Utpadak Vikrete Sahkari Sanstha and Kelshi Parisar Amba Utpadak Sahakari Sangha Maryadit, was given registered proprietor status by the GI registry.

THE DEVGAD MANOEUVRE

Faced with these challenges, Devgad cultivators have now taken some action. Starting this season, Devgad mangoes will come with a unique tamper-proof sticker with an embedded code. Using a dedicated WhatsApp number, customers will be able to verify if the mango is from Devgad, its cultivator, and the location of the mango orchard. The use of these stickers, says Gogate, will help consumers get authentic fruit, and ensure that orchard owners in Devgad get a good price. In the first year, the sanstha plans to cover 10 million mangoes meant for sale. Gradually, it wants to scale it up. Gogate says they were calling on mango farmers to register themselves with the sanstha for the stickers. So far, around 750 of the 5,000 Alphonso cultivators in Devgad have come on board.

Prashant Yadav, managing director of Sun Solutions, which developed the sticker, says the data in it is not only encrypted but also easy to read. Buyers have to tear off the sticker from the mango, which has nine open digits, and send a photograph to a dedicated WhatsApp number. They will then be prompted for the two hidden digits behind the sticker, after which they will be sent details about whether the product is genuine, the name of the farmer and the location of the orchard. These details will be seeded with the stickers in the database. Priced between Rs 1.5 and Rs 2, depending on the scale, these stickers will be single-use and pasted on each fruit. "We decided to paste single-use stickers based on patented technology on individual fruits instead of the box itself to prevent any tampering," explains Sapre.

Alphonso growers in other parts of the Konkan are also deliberating ways to protect the brand. "There is a genuine problem of adulteration when it comes to the Alphonso," says Dr Vivek Bhide, president, Konkan Hapus Amba Utpadak Ani Utpadak Vikrete Sahkari Sanstha, Ratnagiri. "The Alphonso has a certain value and charisma mangoes from other states lack. This adulteration affects the brand value of the Konkan Alphonso and prevents farmers from getting a good price." Apart from mislabelling table fruits, he points out, less costly mangoes from other regions are also mixed with Alphonso pulp to make products that can be sold cheaper. This affects the mango pulp producers in the Konkan. Since last year, Bhide's society has urged farmers to use QR codes on fruits or boxes to enable consumers to identify the grower, location of the orchard and date of plucking. However, growers have been slow to adopt the technology due to the low turnaround time in harvesting and transporting the fruit to the markets.



"For years, mangoes from other parts have been sold as Devgad mangoes, but our mangoes have a different quality and taste"

AJIT GOGATE
Chairman, Devgad Taluka Amba Utpadak Sahakari Sanstha Maryadit

ID PROOF

- This season, Devgad mangoes will come with a tamper-proof sticker
- Buyers have to tear off the sticker, take a picture of the nine open digits and send it to a dedicated WhatsApp number
- They will be prompted for two hidden digits behind the sticker
- They will then be told if the mango is genuine, the name of the cultivator and the orchard it's come from



IRON-CLAD IDENTITY

Alphonso cultivators are not too happy with the government either, blaming its laxity in implementing the GI regime for their current predicament. "The government has confined its role to issuing GI certification, doing little to enforce and implement the GI regime, promote GI products, upgrade them and crack down on violations," says Bhide. Mandar Desai of the Desai Bandhu Ambewale, Pune, thinks the same, and says enforcing the GI regime and checking and preventing violations and not promoting the use of stickers should be a priority. In fact, Desai, who is the fourth generation from his family in the business and has over 400 acres of mango plantations in Pavas in Ratnagiri, is against Devgad cultivators seeking a separate identity for their Alphonso, saying there is little difference in the mangoes grown in Devgad and Ratnagiri.

The overall sentiment in the community, however, is for enforcement of the GI norms. Doing so, says Mahesh M. Kulkarni, assistant professor in the department of horticulture at the College of Agriculture in Dr Balasaheb Sawant Konkan Krishi Vidyapeeth, Dapoli, Ratnagiri, would work in favour of the consumers. "It is necessary to make consumers aware. They pay for the taste (of Alphonsos) and hence must get authentic products," he stresses. Advocate Ganesh Hingmire, founder and chairman of the Great Mission Group Society and an Intellectual Property (IP) enthusiast, says such initiatives will fulfil the purpose of getting GI tags by weeding out duplicate products, and serve the interests of both farmers and consumers. A win-win situation for all. ■